

Stroke (Brain Attack)

What is a Stroke?

A stroke occurs when blood supply to part of the brain is cut off, either by a clot blocking an artery (ischemic stroke, 87%) or by a blood vessel rupturing (hemorrhagic stroke).

A transient ischemic attack (TIA or mini-stroke) causes temporary symptoms and is a major warning sign of an impending stroke.

Symptoms — Use FAST

F - Face drooping: Ask the person to smile. Is one side drooping?

A - Arm weakness: Ask them to raise both arms. Does one arm drift downward?

S - Speech difficulty: Is speech slurred, garbled, or unable to speak?

T - Time to call 112/911: If ANY of these signs are present, call emergency services IMMEDIATELY.

Other symptoms: sudden severe headache ('thunderclap'), vision loss in one or both eyes, sudden loss of balance or coordination, confusion.

Medicines

Ischemic stroke: tPA (alteplase) is a clot-busting drug given within 4.5 hours of symptom onset at hospital.

Mechanical thrombectomy (clot removal procedure) possible within 24 hours at specialized centers.

Long-term prevention: aspirin or clopidogrel (antiplatelet), anticoagulants (warfarin, rivaroxaban) if atrial fibrillation is present.

Statins and antihypertensive medications are essential for stroke prevention.

Hemorrhagic stroke treatment: blood pressure control, reversal of anticoagulation, possible surgery.

Emergency Actions

CALL 112/911 IMMEDIATELY. Note the exact time symptoms started — this is critical for treatment.

Do NOT give food, water, or any medications by mouth — the person may be unable to swallow.

Do not let the patient sleep it off. Every minute counts: 'Time is Brain.'

If the patient is unconscious, check breathing and put in recovery position.

Go to the nearest stroke-ready hospital (comprehensive stroke center if available).

What You Should Do

Control stroke risk factors: hypertension, diabetes, high cholesterol, atrial fibrillation.

Quit smoking, limit alcohol, exercise regularly, maintain healthy weight.

Take all prescribed medications consistently. Do not skip anticoagulants.

After a stroke: follow rehabilitation plan (physiotherapy, speech therapy, occupational therapy).

Recognize TIA symptoms and seek emergency care — it is a warning that a major stroke may follow.